PROJECT WORTH

GROOMING AWARENESS FOR TEENS

— Sometimes grooming feels like being chosen. —



DID YOU KNOW?

"Had I learned about grooming while I was being abused, I do not think I would have recognized it. I believed I was special. I thought the attention meant I was trusted, mature, and important.

As an adult, I understand the situation differently. I was a young person who trusted someone with authority over me, and that trust was exploited. When I reported the abuse years later, I learned that other adults had noticed warning signs or had opportunities to intervene. They could have done more to protect me, but chose not to."

— Kerri, Founder of Project Worth

Teens deserve to know the signs. Adults are responsible for noticing, responding, and protecting them.

WHAT GROOMING IS

Grooming is a hidden pathway an adult may use to gain a young person's trust, cross boundaries, and take advantage of them while appearing safe, caring, or helpful.

It may involve an adult, someone in authority, an older teen, or someone online.

WARNING SIGNS

- Unusual attention, gifts, rides, money, or privileges
- Calling you "more mature" than people your age
- Isolating you from friends, family, or safe adults
- Private messages, late-night chats, or disappearing apps
- Secrets about gifts, meetings, messages, or the relationship
- Sexual jokes, images, body comments, or unwanted touching
- Jealousy, control, or making you responsible for their feelings

ONLINE GROOMING CAN LOOK LIKE

- Moving conversations to private apps
- Asking for personal or sexual photos
- Pressuring you to video chat or meet in person
- Threatening to share messages or images

WHAT YOU SHOULD KNOW

- It is never your fault when an adult manipulates, pressures, or exploits your trust.
- The problem is not that you trusted them. The responsibility belongs to the adult who misused that trust.
- You are not responsible for protecting an adult from the consequences of their choices.
- Safe adults respect your boundaries and never use attention, gifts, help, or secrecy to control you. You can always ask for help.
- You are a person of great worth and potential. No one gets to define your value or take credit for who you are becoming.
- You deserve relationships built on honesty, safety, respect, and freedom.

TRUST THE UNEASY FEELING

A relationship may not seem clearly dangerous but can still leave you feeling confused, pressured, isolated, uncomfortable, or unsure.

Talk to a safe adult, even when you cannot fully explain what feels wrong. If the first person does not listen, keep telling until someone helps.

GET HELP

If you feel unsafe, confused, pressured, or trapped, reach out to a trusted adult.

Emergency
Call 911 if you are in immediate danger.

RAINN National Sexual Assault Hotline
800-656-HOPE (4673) | online.rainn.org

Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline
Call or text 1-800-4-A-CHILD | 1-800-422-4453
childhelphotline.org

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline
Call or text 988

Your light matters. Your voice matters. You are never alone.

PROTECTING KIDS. | CHANGING SYSTEMS. | EMPOWERING SURVIVORS.

Together, we light up the darkness.